



20% girls in Delhi and Chennai studying in Class 6 smoke, says an AIIMS survey

87% Hindi movies show onscreen smoking; **26%** have a heroine who smokes

In the dimly lit, woody interior of the German Bakery in Koregaon Park in Pune, Nandini Gupta and her friends from the Symbiosis Institute of Media & Communication tuck into fresh organic breads and pomegranate juice with relish. Here they also enjoy a quiet smoke. "Out of 100 girls in my second year postgraduate class, nearly 20 per cent smoke," she says. "For most, it's not a rebellion. They smoke because they're used to it. They probably took to smoking in school or college—along with boys in their class—and now can't give up. Just like boys."

"Just like boys" is the operative word. Catch the "new mindscape". A 2005 study by the Grey Global Group on 3,400 unmarried women in 10 cities found 52 per cent young single women aspiring for big houses and big cars; 65 per cent held dating to be essential before marriage; over 76 per cent wished to maintain financial independence post-marriage; 60 per cent said they would decide how to spend their own money and 76 per cent, when to have children. "In the new millennium, as more women pursue higher studies, as new job opportunities make women become more important in the marketplace—not just as workers, but also as consumers, entrepreneurs, managers and investors—and as prejudice fades, smoking becomes a way of keeping up with men," says Bangladeshi writer,

Taslima Nasreen—a former smoker who had picked up the habit from men.

"Men are also changing," says Nimika, a Delhi girl who now works with KPO company, Genpact in Bangalore. As a student at the Delhi School of Economics, she recalls, how "normal" it was for a male student to offer a cigarette to his women friends. "The same is true at office. Men and women mingle at short smoke breaks." Does she see a pattern among women who smoke? "Smoking is common more among westernised girls, those with liberal and generous parents and partners, those who left home early—to study or to work—and had boys as friends early on."

Not surprisingly, researchers are probing conjugal relationships. A study published in *Social Science and Medicine* last year tried to show that families where couples have more equal relationships (and a wife can smoke with or in front of her husband) often do not enjoy good health. New studies are mushrooming on the amount of passive smoking wives get in India. According to a survey conducted by the Chittaranjan National Cancer Research Hospital in Kolkata, 85 per cent middle-class Bengali men smoke at home. Unhappy conjugality also pushes women toward smoking, says yet another piece of research from